

Overdrawing on Experience: Panpsychism and the Limits of First-Person Warrant

Abstract

Panpsychism often draws its force from an epistemic asymmetry. Physical science seems to describe matter in structural, relational, dispositional, or dynamic terms, while consciousness is known directly from the first-person point of view. This paper argues that the appeal is genuine but limited. The issue is not whether first-person experience alone proves panpsychism, but whether the warrant supplied by first-person experience can transfer to the hidden posits panpsychism introduces. First-person experience establishes consciousness as a datum and shows that the experiences with which we are acquainted have phenomenal character. It does not, by itself, disclose bare metaphysical subjectivity, micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, or relations of phenomenal inheritance. When panpsychism introduces those further posits, their support has to come from theory rather than from acquaintance itself. This places the argument in debates over introspection and the revelation thesis: first-person acquaintance supports the datum of consciousness, not a hidden phenomenal ontology. It also reframes the emergence pressure. The paper asks what explanatory work remains for a hidden phenomenal base once organization explains the structure of ordinary consciousness. Panpsychism remains available as metaphysics, but it forfeits the special authority of first-person evidence when it moves beyond ordinary consciousness into hidden phenomenal ontology.

Keywords: panpsychism; first-person warrant; introspection; revelation thesis; Russellian monism; knowledge of consciousness; phenomenal consciousness; panprotopsychism; cosmopsychism; explanatory gap

1 Introduction: Panpsychism's Appeal

Panpsychism derives much of its contemporary appeal from an epistemic asymmetry. Consciousness, unlike many entities posited by physical science, is known from the first-person point of view. When I am in pain, I do not posit the pain as I posit an electron or a gene; the pain is given in the experience. Physical science, by contrast, is often taken to describe matter in structural, relational, and dispositional terms. It tells us how matter behaves, but not, at least on one influential line of thought, what occupies those roles intrinsically. If consciousness is the one reality known from the inside, then perhaps consciousness, or something consciousness-like, belongs in

our account of fundamental reality. This thought gives panpsychism its distinctive force. It promises to avoid the apparent emergence of consciousness from an entirely non-conscious base by locating mentality, proto-mentality, or phenomenal character in the nature of matter itself. In its more sophisticated forms, the view is not the simple claim that electrons have recognizably human-like minds. Strawson’s realistic monism, for example, argues that a serious physicalism must take experience as part of the physical world and cannot treat experiential reality as an inexplicable late arrival (Strawson 2006). Goff’s Russellian monist defense places panpsychism in a broader argument about the categorical nature of matter and the limits of structural physics (Goff 2017a). The field also divides between micropsychist views, which begin from many small subjects and try to combine them into human minds, and cosmopsychist views, which begin from a single cosmic subject and try to derive local minds from it; both forms figure in what follows.

A prominent motivation is epistemic: consciousness has a special status because it is known directly from within. Panpsychists may also appeal to the alleged impossibility of radical emergence, to continuity in nature, to theoretical simplicity, to dissatisfaction with standard physicalism, to the explanatory gap, or to a Russellian monist thesis according to which physics leaves the intrinsic nature of matter unspecified. Those arguments raise large issues that cannot be settled here.¹ The target is first-person-motivated panpsychism: any version of the view whose case for undisclosed phenomenal structure depends, even partly, on the special epistemic status of consciousness. Once the view introduces micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, or other hidden phenomenal posits, the first-person beginning must carry a further transition.

Although panpsychism remains a live metaphysical option, one of its most powerful motivations cannot bear all the weight sometimes placed on it. The disputed move is the slide from acquaintance with phenomenal character to a metaphysical claim about the role that phenomenal character plays in the constitution of matter. Acquaintance may reveal what a phenomenal quality is like; the assignment of that quality to a categorical-grounding, microphysical, cosmic, or fundamental role requires further argument. Once the relevant phenomenal posits lie beyond what experience discloses, the emergence problem remains open rather than dissolved in advance. The gap reappears between those theoretical posits and the consciousness we actually undergo. Goff’s recent treatment of subjects as strongly emergent makes this visible from within his own framework (Goff 2024).

2 The Datum

First-person experience gives panpsychism a strong beginning because it establishes that consciousness is real and discloses something about what conscious life is like. The concession is substantial: a theory of consciousness that denies or deflates the first-person datum carries a heavy burden.

¹This bracketing leaves important arguments in place. Alter develops a recent route from the knowledge argument to Russellian monism, Pereboom treats Russellian monism as part of the prospects for physicalism, and Stoljar’s ignorance-based treatment warns against moving too quickly from epistemic limitation to metaphysical conclusion (Alter 2023; Pereboom 2011; Stoljar 2006).

Three questions must be kept apart: whether conscious experience exists, what features it has, and what its metaphysical status is. First-person experience answers the first robustly. It bears on the second more cautiously, since our grasp of phenomenal character may be partial, vague, and fallible. The third requires further metaphysical argument. Acquaintance with experience leaves open whether consciousness is fundamental, intrinsic, derivative, organizational, microphysical, or cosmic.

In perceptual introspection, attention often seems to pass through the experience to what it presents: the red surface, the edge, the sound, the pain, the pressure, the mood (Dretske 1995; Tye 2000). That familiar transparency supports the limit defended here. Introspection can give phenomenal character at some grain while leaving the metaphysical status of that character underdescribed. Schwitzgebel's doubts about introspective reliability reinforce the same caution: even within its proper domain, introspection does not by itself disclose metaphysical structure (Schwitzgebel 2008, 2011).

What experience supplies is real but finite: consciousness at the grain of acquaintance, experience as given, with some phenomenal character however attenuated. A mood may be vague, peripheral vision indeterminate, and anticipation foggy; these are still ways experience is given. Vagueness and fogginess are phenomenal characters, not routes to subjectivity without character. The same point applies to harder cases, including minimal experience, meditative states, moods, objectless anxiety, dreamless-sleep reports, and claims about pure consciousness. Those cases may be granted. They give us experience as given, not a metaphysical verdict about the distribution, fundamentality, or cosmic structure of consciousness.

First-person evidence is indispensable for consciousness, but its authority reaches what it presents. Micro-experience, proto-experience, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, cosmic subjectivity, and phenomenal bonding relations require another source of warrant.

3 The Introspective Warrant Constraint

3.1 The constraint stated

When panpsychism draws force from the special epistemic status of consciousness, it begins from a real asymmetry. Consciousness is not known in the way electrons, genes, or black holes are known. I do not posit my current pain as a theoretical entity; I undergo it from the first-person point of view.

Direct knowledge of consciousness gives warrant for what is actually given in experience, while entities described as phenomenal, proto-phenomenal, or experiential acquire that standing only when they are given in the relevant way. First-person acquaintance gives immediate warrant for the occurrence and character of the experience one is acquainted with. Claims about the distribution, fundamentality, categorical role, or cosmic or microphysical basis of consciousness require further support. That is the introspective warrant constraint:

A theory that motivates itself by appeal to first-person experience may claim first-person warrant only for what first-person experience actually discloses.

The constraint leaves room for theoretical posits, since physics, biology, and psychology all legitimately posit entities and structures outside experience. Those posits are warranted by explanatory, predictive, or unificatory work rather than by inherited first-person authority. If panpsychism posits micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, undisclosed phenomenal bases, or relations of phenomenal inheritance, those posits may be defended as theoretical entities. Their support must be earned by the work they do, not drawn from the mere fact that consciousness is first-personally given.

In schematic form:

1. First-person acquaintance warrants only what experience actually discloses.
2. What experience discloses is consciousness at the grain of acquaintance: experience as given, with some phenomenal character however attenuated.
3. It does not disclose micro-experience, proto-experience, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, cosmic subjectivity, or relations of phenomenal bonding or inheritance.
4. So those posits do not inherit first-person warrant.
5. If they are defended, they must be defended by theoretical virtues rather than direct first-person warrant.

Because the first step concerns warrant rather than existence, it leaves every panpsychist posit metaphysically open while denying a specific source of support. Such posits must find their warrant outside first-person acquaintance. A panpsychist may reply, correctly, that no careful defender claims first-person experience alone proves panpsychism. The stronger argument is abductive: consciousness is known directly; physics gives only structure; radical emergence looks suspect; panpsychism is offered as the best metaphysical hypothesis. Even inside this abduction, however, the first-person datum can be made to carry more weight than the abduction earns.

3.2 Hidden posits and first-person warrant

Panpsychism crosses the relevant line when it moves from consciousness as given in acquaintance to hidden phenomenal posits. Contemporary panpsychist and panprotopsylist views may posit micro-experience, proto-experience, proto-phenomenal properties, cosmic subjectivity, undisclosed phenomenal bases, phenomenal bonding relations, or forms of phenomenal inheritance. These posits lie beyond direct first-person disclosure. The immediacy of pain warrants the pain itself; the directness of visual experience warrants that visual experience occurs. Claims about a cosmic subject behind the pain, or about phenomenal natures in the microphysical story of vision, require further argument.

Revelation is the strongest principle by which acquaintance might be thought to reach farther. In its strong form, defended by Goff, phenomenal concepts “reveal the complete nature of the conscious states they refer to”: attending to a pain or a color experience, one grasps what that experience is (Goff 2017a, 106–132). Even that strong version leaves the quality/role distinction untouched. Grant that introspection reveals the complete nature of the phenomenal quality one undergoes. The quality is one thing; the metaphysical role of the property that bears it is another. Acquaintance may reveal what a phenomenal quality is like. It does not reveal that the property

so encountered plays the categorical-grounding role. That role assignment is theoretical. Roelofs’s moderate revelation thesis makes the same limit visible from the other direction: constitutive panpsychism can be protected only if introspection need not disclose every constitutive fact transparently (Roelofs 2020). That concession is not a defeat for panpsychism. It marks the point at which hidden constitution must be defended by theory rather than by the direct authority of acquaintance.

The warrant issue is prior to familiar debates about combination.² Whether micro-experiences can combine into macro-consciousness is a further question. Before such machinery is assessed, there must be warrant for positing micro-experiences, bonding relations, proto-phenomenal powers, composite subjects, or cosmic subjectivity. If those posits are justified by solving explanatory problems, their warrant is theoretical rather than first-personal.

The panprotopsychist can deny that fundamental entities are conscious while assigning them proto-phenomenal or proto-experiential properties that help explain consciousness. Proto-experience brings the problem into sharp relief because it is encountered, if at all, as a theoretical posit. Introspection is, by what it does, acquaintance with experience; its reach is whatever reach experience has. Calling something proto-experiential in the same breath as experience does not extend acquaintance to it. If proto-experience is sufficiently like experience, it inherits familiar problems about structure, unity, subjecthood, and combination. If it is sufficiently unlike experience, it loses its claim to first-person warrant.

Phenomenal bonding belongs on the theoretical side of the same boundary. Goff’s proposal may be promising as a response to combination worries, but it remains a theoretical structure (Goff 2017b). I am acquainted with pain, color, thought, and temporal flow. Relations by which micro-subjects combine into macro-subjects are introduced by the theory.

4 Applications to Panpsychist Views

The constraint applies unevenly across panpsychist views. It bears most directly on views that treat first-person experience as support for undisclosed phenomenal structure. It also bears on views that argue abductively in their official statements while still drawing dialectical force from first-person privilege. Views that rest entirely on theoretical virtues, without claiming first-person warrant for their posits, are largely untouched. Saad’s argument from psychophysical harmony is a useful example of the third kind (Saad 2022).

Strawson’s realistic monism gives the clearest baseline: experience is real, experience is physical if physicalism is true, and the emergence of experience from the wholly non-experiential would be unintelligible (Strawson 2006). His text leaves the move on the surface. Experience is “the fundamental given natural fact,” and for that reason “the obligatory starting point for any remotely realistic” theory of what

²The nearby literature is extensive. Bruntrup maps the contemporary combination-problem terrain; Chalmers distinguishes panpsychism from panprotopsychism and treats combination as a central obstacle; Coleman presses the subject-summing problem; Mørch develops a phenomenal-powers view; Roelofs defends composite subjectivity; Nagel’s classic discussion asks whether panpsychism follows from claims about mental properties, reduction, and composition (Brüntrup and Jaskolla 2017; Chalmers 2015, 2017; Coleman 2014; Mørch 2020, *forthcoming*; Roelofs 2019; Nagel 1979).

there is (Strawson 2006, 4). The inference runs from the certainty of the datum to a constraint on fundamental theory: nothing is more certain than that experience occurs, so any realistic account of what exists must build experience in at the ground. Strawson may be right that experience is part of reality and cannot be dismissed. First-person acquaintance with experience still does not warrant the stronger claim that experientiality exists at the fundamental level.

Goff’s more elaborate Russellian and cosmopsychist machinery makes the problem sharper. His work develops panpsychism within a structure/dynamics framework and addresses the combination problem through phenomenal bonding and cosmopsychism (Goff 2017a,b, 2019). Goff says that properly internalizing consciousness as a datum is “epistemically transformative,” because it makes room for panpsychist views that third-person observation and experiment do not themselves support (Goff 2017a, 9–10). He also treats first-person consciousness as a distinctive metaphysical datum, grounded in our “direct access to the essence of our conscious states” (Goff 2017a, 265). He then presents panpsychist Russellian monism as the view that “deep narrowly material facts” are “themselves phenomenal facts” (Goff 2017a, 144). Acquaintance may disclose the experience; it does not by itself disclose that phenomenal character occupies the deep-nature role. Goff’s positive case can still be defended abductively: the intrinsic nature of the matter of brains is taken to be consciousness-involving, and the most parsimonious hypothesis is that matter elsewhere is continuous with it. That form of argument is legitimate, and it claims no acquaintance with electrons. The pressure falls instead on its starting point. That the intrinsic categorical nature of brain matter is consciousness-involving is a metaphysical reading of acquaintance, not a deliverance of it.

Cosmopsychism reverses the micropsychist direction. Instead of beginning with many micro-subjects and combining them into human subjects, it begins with a cosmic subject and derives local subjects from it. Although this may avoid some versions of the combination problem, it intensifies the introspective warrant problem. Cosmic subjectivity is hidden from third-person science and unlike anything first-person experience discloses. First-person experience reveals local, finite, perspectival consciousness with determinate phenomenal character. It is also bounded and affectively grained: one is acquainted with one’s own experiences and not with anyone else’s, and what is given is given as mattering in some way, pleasant or aversive or neutral. A cosmopsychist may reply that such boundedness is exactly what cosmic consciousness is like when localized, partitioned, or dissociated. Even if that is coherent, the cosmic subject as cosmic remains outside introspection; the defense is a metaphysical model of individuation rather than a deliverance of first-person acquaintance. The datum has perspectival closure and affective valence built into it, and neither feature is delivered by a unified cosmic experiencer from which local minds derive.

Cosmopsychism need not be treated as a simple mirror image of micropsychism’s combination problem.³ Even if these views offer a coherent theory of cosmic individuation, the cosmic subject is not disclosed in first-person acquaintance. Its warrant

³Shani resists that framing, arguing that cosmopsychic individuation need not be understood as the reverse of micropsychist subject-summing. Albahari and Mørch likewise explore versions of cosmic consciousness that complicate simple charges about decombination and unity (Shani 2015, 2022; Albahari 2019; Mørch 2024).

comes from the broader metaphysical picture, not from an expanded introspective datum.

Goff's recent hybrid cosmopsychism treats subjects as strongly emergent while phenomenal properties are weakly emergent (Goff 2024). The division is meant to let panpsychism help with consciousness without inheriting the worst of the subject-combination problem. Goff's view need not collapse for that concession to matter. The anti-emergentist motivation has narrowed: it no longer covers subjecthood itself, and so cannot by itself secure the full first-person datum. Once panpsychism explains subjecthood through emergence, grounding, and whole-to-part structure, it is doing theoretical metaphysics. The theoretical phenomenal base it introduces cannot retain the immediacy of the original first-person datum.

On Mørch's phenomenal powers view, phenomenal properties are not idle qualia but powers that can ground physical dispositions (Mørch 2020, forthcoming). If successful, this would give panpsychism a substantive explanatory role. It also makes the constraint sharper. First-person experience may acquaint us with phenomenal character, and perhaps with agency, motivation, effort, or felt efficacy in action. That concession still leaves a large gap. Human agency involves temporality, intention, goal-representation, bodily feedback, and a distinction between trying and succeeding. A minimal causal power that lacks those features may be a legitimate theoretical posit, but it is no longer the agency or effort given in first-person experience. Mørch's argument is explicitly theoretical, and to that extent not the paper's target. Still, it is motivated by a knowledge claim: the case for phenomenal grounds runs through the premise that "the only categorical properties we know are phenomenal properties" (Mørch 2020). The explicit argument is abductive, while the consideration that recommends it is the privilege the constraint examines.

A constitutive panpsychist may press the point in the other direction, and Roelofs develops the most careful version: if the consciousness we undergo is literally constituted by micro-experiences, then introspecting it already amounts to indirect acquaintance with what makes it up. Constitutive panpsychism, Roelofs argues, need not predict introspective access to micro-properties: they constitute what is introspected without themselves appearing as objects of introspection. He grants that we are "unable to tell introspectively just how composite" our experience "might really be" (Roelofs 2020, 89). Constitution and acquaintance are different relations. Cells constitute me, but I am not acquainted with my cells by being acquainted with myself. Even granting the constitutive picture, introspection presents the integrated whole rather than the items that compose it. Acquaintance presents at some grain, and that is the grain at which warrant is given; a coarser-grain acquaintance does not by itself deliver finer-grain acquaintance with whatever constitutes it. Roelofs warns against "inferring absence of structure from the failure of structure to be manifest" (Roelofs 2020, 87), and the warning is well taken, since the constraint draws no such inference. Its conclusion is about warrant, not existence: introspection does not warrant the micro-level, and that leaves its existence entirely open. Roelofs's own account

agrees, treating the micro-level as introspectively undisclosed and defensible only by its theoretical role in explaining the macro-consciousness that is disclosed.⁴

Ramm’s argument is direct because first-person reflection is explicitly asked to do metaphysical work. The first-person starting point is part of the route to an idealist-panpsychist picture (Ramm 2021). Reflection can begin such a route, but later metaphysical structure still needs its own warrant.

The constraint targets a pattern of warrant, not individual writers. When a panpsychist treats the inference as fully abductive, the point is already conceded. The comparative case for panpsychism often depends on the claim that it takes consciousness more seriously than rival views can. Once the micro-level, cosmic level, or bonding relation lies outside introspective disclosure, first-person evidence gives way to theoretical support. The view may still be defended, but the special first-person authority no longer carries the later posit.

5 The Abstraction Problem

Descriptions of the first-person datum as bare subjectivity, pure awareness, or mere what-it-is-likeness are tempting because they seem to isolate the minimal feature common to all conscious states. They also risk abstracting away the features that make consciousness intelligible as a datum.

When we attend to consciousness, what is given has character. In familiar waking cases, we find sensation, mood, thought, temporal flow, embodiment, and varying degrees of attention. Less familiar cases should be treated with care. A meditative state, an objectless mood, or a claimed pure-consciousness state may lack many features of standard waking experience. But insofar as it is available to first-person acquaintance, it is available as something: calm, blank, diffuse, silent, contentless, expansive, or otherwise phenomenally determinate. The experiences we can appeal to as evidence need not represent external objects, but neither are they given as bare metaphysical subjectivity.

Appeals to fundamental subjectivity face a dilemma. Does the posited fundamental consciousness have phenomenal character, or not? With phenomenal character, it already has structure of some determinate sort. Without phenomenal character, it is an abstraction from experience rather than something first-person experience discloses.

The dilemma is especially important for views that retreat from rich consciousness to minimal subjectivity. The move is understandable. Few panpsychists want to say that electrons have visual fields, memories, anxieties, or personal identities. So the relevant posit is often thinned out. The fundamental level is said to contain minimal phenomenal character, bare subjectivity, or proto-experiential nature. Thinning the posit changes its epistemic status. The thinner it becomes, the less it resembles the consciousness that first-person experience actually gives. Thinning also leaves the first horn of the dilemma in place. Whatever phenomenal character is retained, however minimal, is character of some determinate sort; structure does not vanish just because the posit has been made small. A posit with minimal phenomenal character still

⁴Lin argues that revelation cannot favor panpsychism over physicalism, while Roelofs argues that constitutive panpsychists can accept a medium-strength revelation thesis without transparent introspective access to every constitutive fact (Lin 2025; Roelofs 2020).

has phenomenal character, and first-person acquaintance with our experience does not by itself warrant that character's distribution, fundamentality, or microphysical placement.

A natural reply is that panpsychism is doing what scientific theorizing often does: abstracting a property from familiar cases and assigning it to entities in which it does not appear in familiar form. We abstract mass from heavy bodies and assign it to particles we cannot feel. Why not abstract phenomenality from experience and assign it to the fundamental level?

The analogy is useful because mass is embedded in a network of measurement and intervention that supplies warrant for applying it beyond the cases in which we first encounter it. We know what it would be for an unfamiliar entity to have mass, because mass has behavioral signatures that can be tracked without acquaintance. Its identity is fixed by its role in theory and practice, not by the felt heaviness of familiar objects. Phenomenality is different. We encounter it only as some way the experience is given. If phenomenality is stripped of temporality, perspective, valence, and every determinate mode of givenness, it is unclear what property has been isolated. The panpsychist may answer that the residue is simply what-it-is-likeness. Naming the residue leaves the dilemma in place: either it is some determinate way an experience is given, and so has phenomenal character, or it is no way of being given at all. Mass avoids this fork because its identity never rested on a felt mode of givenness. For phenomenality, the determinate modes of givenness do the individuating work, and the abstraction removes just those modes. The panpsychist may still posit a thin phenomenal property, but the posit is now theoretical. It no longer carries the first-person authority of the experience from which the abstraction began.

A related reply says that minimal phenomenal character can be primitive at the fundamental level, in the sense that it is not further analyzable into more basic phenomenal constituents, while still being determinate. The first horn of the dilemma is then conceded, but its consequence is denied: determinate character need not call for reductive explanation if no further phenomenal analysis is available. The primitive can be granted without granting the warrant transfer. Acquaintance with determinate character in our own case does not by itself license claims about where such character is distributed, whether it is fundamental, or whether it belongs at the microphysical level. Granting the primitive's coherence also leaves the main panpsychist debt in place: the route from a primitive micro-character to the determinate macro-consciousness we have. The dilemma's purpose was not to require reductive analysis of phenomenality. It was to show that bare characterless subjectivity cannot be the datum, and that any determinate alternative cannot simply inherit the first-person warrant of the experience from which it was abstracted.

Frankish's worry about the depsychologization of consciousness presses nearby ([Frankish 2021](#)). The more consciousness is stripped of the psychological roles by which we ordinarily recognize it, the less clear it becomes that the retained posit is still the consciousness from which the argument began. The argument here does not require illusionism. A more modest point is enough: a depsychologized or contentless posit may be coherent, but it is not simply the first-person datum under another name.

Even at the most attenuated end of waking consciousness, something is given. There is some sense of presence, of for-me-ness, of the moment's being a moment for the one undergoing it. That sense is itself a phenomenal character, however thin, and not a structureless occupant of consciousness. The claim is phenomenological: it concerns what acquaintance presents, not what a later report or memory can reconstruct.

5.1 Pure Awareness

The difficult case is reported awareness with most familiar structure suspended: consciousness without object, self, or thought. These reports should be taken seriously, since they may seem to approach the bare subjectivity the preceding argument denies is given in experience. If pure awareness has some phenomenal character, even an attenuated one such as silence, openness, presence, or bare temporality, it is not characterless subjectivity. If it has no phenomenal character at all, it is not disclosed as experience in the way pain or temporal flow is disclosed. Either way, the appeal to pure awareness does not license the transfer from first-person acquaintance to a hidden ontology of bare fundamental consciousness.

The literature gives this challenge real support. Metzinger develops minimal phenomenal experience as a candidate for the simplest form of consciousness, drawing on meditative reports of pure awareness and tonic alertness (Metzinger 2020); Gamma and Metzinger, surveying meditators on what is “often described as a contentless form of experience,” find that such reports still resolve into a multi-factor phenomenal profile, with dimensions such as felt time, silence, peace, and wakeful presence (Gamma and Metzinger 2021); and philosophical treatments of witness-consciousness and pure awareness suggest that awareness may be present without object-directed content, self-identification, or discursive thought (Albahari 2006, 2009; Thompson 2014). Meditation-induced cessations make the evidential problem vivid: what reaches the discussion is always a report of an episode in which familiar forms of consciousness were said to be absent (Laukkonen et al. 2023).

These cases can be granted for the sake of argument. The argument need not deny that there are minimal, nondual, selfless, or apparently contentless states, nor decide whether *nirodha samapatti* is best described as consciousness without content, absence of consciousness, or a remembered transition around an absence. The evidential issue arises when such states are used in public philosophical argument. They reach the theorist through report, memory, interpretation, and later classification, and a later report does not settle what structure the episode had. A sympathetic reader may object that the report is only a later trace, while the evidence itself is the private episode. Private acquaintance, if it occurs, may be compelling for the subject before any report is made. For everyone else, the episode is available only through what is remembered, described, and classified. Even apart from that public step, the appeal divides the same way: if the episode was given as silence, openness, presence, bare temporality, or some other way of seeming, it had phenomenal character; if nothing was given, there is no first-person disclosure of experience for panpsychism to extend.

A report used as evidence carries built-in commitments. A reportable episode must be retained or reconstructed in memory and attributed to the subject who reports

it; Lin presses this for selfless states, where it is hard to see how an autobiographical memory could establish what a wholly selfless episode was like (Lin 2022). It must also be located, at least minimally, in a before-and-after order; Windt argues that even content-poor sleep experience involves a minimal temporality, a duration or a sense of having been (Windt 2015). Experiential subjectivity may also remain tied to a minimal for-me-ness or bodily perspective, as Zahavi argues and as Henry and Thompson press against Albahari (Zahavi 2005; Henry and Thompson 2011). Each point cuts the same way. If the structure is present, the report attests to more than bare subjectivity. If it is absent, the retrospective report cannot establish the episode as a first-person datum lacking it.

Contentless-awareness reports still have evidential value. At most, they support attenuated phenomenal character, reduced object-directedness, weakened self-representation, or unusual temporal and bodily structure. The more a report says was absent during the episode, whether memory, selfhood, or temporal grain, the more cautiously it must be used, since the ordinary conditions for accurate retrospective report are exactly what it says were suspended. Schwitzgebel’s worries about introspective unreliability compound the restriction (Schwitzgebel 2008, 2011).

6 The Russellian Vacancy

The Russellian monist can press a further argument. Physics, it is said, gives us only structure and dynamics. It describes relations, dispositions, equations, and causal roles. It leaves open the intrinsic or categorical nature of the entities that bear those roles. Consciousness, by contrast, is known from within. Perhaps consciousness reveals what matter is intrinsically, or at least gives us a model for what intrinsic nature could be (Goff 2017a; Alter 2023; Pereboom 2011).

Structural description really is limited in the relevant sense. If a theory tells us only how entities are related or how they behave, one may ask what, if anything, has the structure or grounds the dispositions. Alter’s recent defense of Russellian monism makes the vacancy more than a rhetorical device: the claim is that standard physical description omits intrinsic properties that may both underlie physical structure and bear on consciousness (Alter 2023). Pereboom’s discussion matters for a different reason. It shows that Russellian monism need not be introduced as a straightforward rejection of physicalism, but can be explored as part of a physicalist response to arguments from consciousness (Pereboom 2011). These uses differ, but they share the thought that physical description may leave an intrinsic-nature question open.

Two claims should be kept distinct. One is that physics leaves categorical nature unspecified. The other is that consciousness is our only acquaintance with categorical nature. The first claim identifies a vacancy. The second tries to fill it. It also carries the weight, because first-person experience gives consciousness as phenomenal character, not as categorical nature already interpreted. We know pain as pain, color-experience as color-experience, mood as mood. Whether the property so encountered is intrinsic categorical nature, derivative organization, emergent process, or something else is a further metaphysical reading of the datum.

The pull toward phenomenal filling is understandable. If physics leaves categorical nature unspecified, and if consciousness is the one concrete reality whose nature seems available from the inside, then consciousness appears to be the only available model of intrinsic nature. The move is not arbitrary; it tries to use the one apparent case of acquaintance to illuminate what structural physics leaves dark. Yet the fact that the model is the only one available tells us about the reach of our concepts rather than the nature of matter. A vacancy we cannot characterize is better left uncharacterized than filled by default with the one notion we happen to have. The absence of a rival model is as consistent with that nature being unknown as with the panpsychist's reading.

Russellian monism can survive this restriction, and a Russellian panpsychist may have further arguments from simplicity, explanatory gap considerations, anti-emergentist premises, or a broader theory of categorical properties. An argument of that form rests on a theory about what best fills an explanatory or metaphysical gap. First-person evidence has unusual authority only within its proper domain. I can be directly aware of my pain. That same act gives me no direct awareness that the intrinsic nature of all matter is pain-like, experience-like, or proto-phenomenal. At most, consciousness supplies a candidate model for intrinsic nature. The suitability of that model must be defended by the theory, since first-person acquaintance supplies the experience itself rather than its fundamental metaphysical role.

7 The Burden Shift

Once panpsychist posits are treated as theoretical rather than first-personal, the burden shifts. Micro-experience, proto-experience, or cosmic subjectivity may be possible. The harder question is what these posits explain. Once first-person warrant is unavailable for them, the relevant phenomenal posits must be justified by explanatory work. This burden is not unique to panpsychism; any theory incurs it once its central posits are no longer directly given.

An adequate theory of consciousness should help explain its unity, its contents, its temporal grain, its sensitivity to factors such as sleep and anesthesia, the difference between processes that enter experience and those that do not, and why experience has valence. Panpsychism need not explain all of these features by its fundamental phenomenal base alone. A panpsychist can reasonably say that attention, memory, reportability, temporal integration, and many contents depend on organization. That concession locates the pressure point more precisely.

If organization explains much of the profile of consciousness as we undergo it, then attention, memory, temporal integration, and reportability may account for why conscious experience has the structure it has while leaving open why there is anything it is like. Panpsychists can therefore say that the theoretical phenomenal base is aimed at phenomenal existence. The theory still has to say what relation that base has to the organized, bounded, valenced consciousness that first-person experience actually gives. If its main role is to block brute emergence from the wholly non-phenomenal, that may be a serious metaphysical role. At that stage, however, the need for an explanation of determinate conscious structure remains. When combination machinery is invoked, the

same burden reappears downstream: micro-experiences, bonding relations, or proto-phenomenal powers must make a distinctive explanatory contribution in virtue of their phenomenal or proto-phenomenal character. Otherwise the theoretical base marks the place where explanation is needed rather than supplying the explanation.

To say this is not to offer a complete emergentist theory of consciousness. Organization has not been shown to derive phenomenality or solve the hard problem; the question remains why any organized processing should feel like anything at all. Still, two explanatory gaps must be distinguished. The first is the physicalist gap: how consciousness arises from a wholly non-conscious base. The second is the gap panpsychism creates for itself: how the unified, determinate consciousness we actually undergo arises from the hidden phenomenal or proto-phenomenal base it posits. These are different gaps. Panpsychism may have resources against the first, but placing phenomenality at the fundamental level leaves the second open, the gap the first-person datum was supposed to have closed in advance. Unless those hidden properties explain enough to justify their theoretical cost, the abductive burden remains in place.

A panpsychist may object that the two gaps are not on a par: the emergence of experience from the wholly non-experiential would be a category error, while the emergence of macro-experience from micro-experience would not. Grant the distinction. It does not restore first-person warrant for the hidden base. Whether macro-from-micro experience escapes a category error is settled, if at all, by an anti-emergentist argument of the kind Section 1 brackets, not by acquaintance; the distinction, if it holds, relocates the defense onto theoretical ground rather than returning it to the immediacy of the datum. Panpsychism would have shown that its gap is more tractable in kind. It would not have shown that the first-person datum has closed it.

Phenomenal-concept strategies press a nearby caution.⁵ The argument here does not require phenomenal concepts to explain away the hard problem. Even if phenomenal concepts or acquaintance give us a distinctive way of thinking about our own experiences, that fact does not extend first-person warrant to micro-experiences, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, or cosmic subjectivity.

Stoljar's ignorance hypothesis gives a related caution. If part of the pressure toward panpsychism arises from ignorance of the relevant physical or categorical facts, the proper response is to separate the datum of consciousness from speculative claims about what must underlie it (Stoljar 2006). The introspective warrant constraint is compatible with the ignorance view but does not require it. Whether or not our ignorance of categorical facts is what generates the pressure toward panpsychism, first-person acquaintance is bounded by what it discloses, and that bound holds even if further categorical facts exist. Before adding hidden phenomenal properties to reality, we should ask what explanatory work they perform beyond marking our resistance to brute emergence.

A panpsychist may reply that this burden is shared. Physicalism also owes an account of why organization gives rise to experience, unless it denies or deflates the

⁵Papineau argues that the felt gap between physical and phenomenal description may arise from how we think about conscious states, and related phenomenal-concept strategies develop the diagnosis in different ways (Papineau 2002; Loar 1990; Balog 2012; Carruthers and Veillet 2007). Mendelovici's discussion of structural problems across theories of consciousness is another useful comparison (Mendelovici 2019).

explanandum, and panpsychism is not alone in facing structural burdens. Independent abductive arguments may also be possible. Panpsychist arguments that make no claim on first-person warrant, of which Saad's harmony argument is the clearest case, are outside the target. The introspective warrant constraint is a discipline on how first-person evidence is used; it has nothing to say about views that do not use it. First-person evidence cannot by itself pay the cost of undisclosed phenomenal structure. Where panpsychism is defended by harmony, phenomenal powers, cosmopsychic individuation, or composite subjectivity, its warrant is theoretical and should be evaluated as such.

Dreamless sleep is a useful illustration. It leaves open whether consciousness is absent. A panpsychist, a Buddhist philosopher, or a theorist of minimal consciousness may argue that some form of experience occurs without later memory. Such a claim requires independent warrant. Where there is no memory, report, phenomenological trace, or distinctive explanatory payoff, first-person evidence supplies no license for the posit.

Temporal grain provides the same kind of illustration. Human consciousness appears to have thresholds and integration windows. Some stimuli may be processed without entering experience at all, and conscious episodes seem to depend on temporally organized uptake rather than on every event in the nervous system surfacing as experience. A panpsychist can say, consistently, that sub-threshold processes still have micro-experiential aspects. That reply still owes an explanation of why conscious episodes have the temporal boundaries they have, why some processed information enters experience while other information does not, or why integration at one scale yields a conscious episode while nearby subpersonal processing remains outside awareness. If hidden experientiality is placed beneath the threshold, it should help explain the threshold. Without such an account, the posit multiplies hidden phenomenal facts beneath temporal structure rather than explaining that structure.

Dreamless sleep and temporal grain leave the metaphysics open. They show a change in kind of warrant: experience-like properties are placed where experience itself gives no clear warrant.

8 Conclusion: The Limits of Special Warrant

For panpsychism, first-person experience remains real evidence: it tells us that consciousness is real and something about what conscious life is like. The same evidence does not tell us that consciousness is fundamental, microphysical, cosmic, or proto-phenomenal. Acquaintance gives us consciousness as datum, not consciousness as fundamental ontology.

Panpsychism may appeal to independent metaphysical arguments, anti-emergentist principles, simplicity considerations, psychophysical harmony, or Russellian claims about intrinsic nature. Those arguments may succeed or fail on their merits. The constraint defended here says only that they may not borrow the authority of first-person experience for entities or structures that first-person experience never reveals. Nothing here vindicates illusionism or deflationary physicalism, since those views face their own burden: denying or deflating the first-person datum carries a substantial cost.

Where panpsychism treats the epistemic privilege of first-person experience as support for micro-experience, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, cosmic subjectivity, phenomenal powers, or other theoretical phenomenal posits, it overdraws on experience. Panpsychism can still be defended, but not as the view whose metaphysical base is already given in experience. Once it moves from acquaintance with phenomenal character to claims about fundamental role, it has moved from acquaintance to theory. Its advantage over rival views has to come from the arguments offered for those theoretical claims.

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